Al Bina — UAE Construction Materials Intelligence

Issue #1 · Nov 8, 2026 · Prepared by @Vk

At a glance

Construction materials demand (how much the UAE uses)

Steel rebar	Cement	Ready-mix concrete	Aggregates for concrete	GGBS
About 6.2 Mt in 2026, up from 5.5 Mt in 2025	About 23.5 Mt in 2026, up from 21.0 Mt in 2025	About 47 million m³ in 2026, up from 42.2 million m³	About 87 Mt in 2026	About 3.8-5.7 Mt in 2026

Market

Business activity (PMI)	Dubai off-plan home sales	New building contracts	Cement company sales	Diesel
54.8 in October (55.3 in Sep; above 50 = growing)	6,698 deals in October	Under USD 5bn in Jul-Sep, 67% lower than a year earlier	EMSTEEL cement AED 287m in Apr-Jun, +29% vs a year earlier	AED 4.75/litre in November, +78% vs a year earlier

Demand figures: cement from Ken Research; the others are Al Bina estimates worked out from published ratios (see "How the three cases are worked out" in the deep dive).

This issue in brief

UAE building materials are in a year of growing and changing demand: more steel, cement and concrete is being used in 2026, but more of the demand now comes from the airport, metro and rail than from housing.

1. **More building materials are being used in 2026: about 6.2 Mt of steel rebar, 23.5 Mt of cement and 47 million m³ of ready-mix concrete, 12-13% more than in 2025**.

2. **Dubai expects a record of about 55,600 completed homes this year**, but new apartment projects fell about 58% and new villa projects about 78% in January to June. So fewer new homes will be built in 2027-28.
3. **New building contracts fell 67% from a year earlier in July to September,** to just under USD 5bn. Gas projects, not buildings, were the biggest new contracts.
4. **The new Al Maktoum airport is the biggest project to watch.** The AED 10bn contract for the West Terminal foundations was signed on 9 October, and over AED 55bn more is due to be signed by the end of the year.
5. **Diesel costs more.** Diesel is AED 4.75 a litre, about 78% higher than a year ago.

Trends: how the market is moving

This section shows the market over five time periods: week, month, quarter, half-year and year. Short periods show what is changing now. Long periods show the bigger direction.

The short story: more building materials are being used and delivery costs more, while Dubai home sales are falling. Dubai home sales from January to October were about one third lower in value than a year ago. But big public projects, such as the new airport and the Blue and Gold metro lines, are taking over as the main source of construction materials demand.

Words used here:

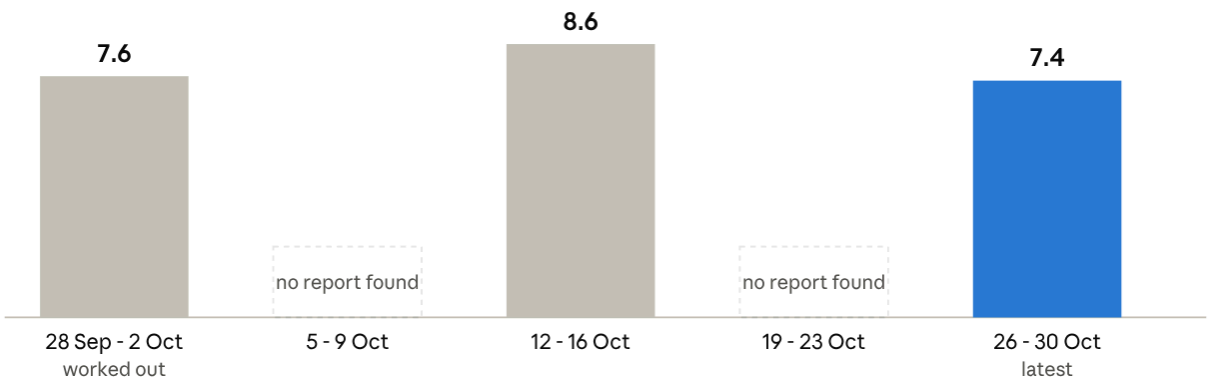
- **Home sales:** homes sold in Dubai, as registered with the Dubai Land Department.
- **Off-plan:** homes sold before they are built. Today's off-plan sales become building work, and orders for construction materials, one to two years later.
- **Diesel:** the fuel trucks use to deliver construction materials, so it drives delivery cost.
- **Listed cement companies:** cement makers whose shares trade on the Abu Dhabi or Dubai stock exchange, so their results are public.

Weekly

Home sales. Weekly sales move up and down, but stayed in a narrow band in October.

Dubai property sales stayed between AED 7bn and 9bn a week in October

Property sales value per week, AED billion (sales only, not mortgages)



Dubai Land Department weekly figures via Sherwoods Property and Arabian Business. 28 Sep - 2 Oct worked out from the 13.3% weekly rise reported for 12 - 16 Oct

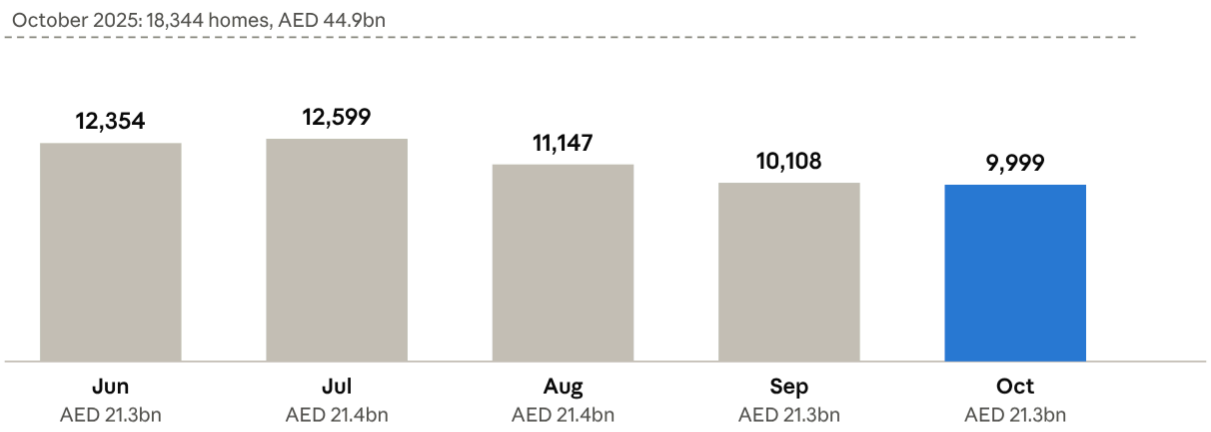
Building materials. No public source publishes construction materials prices every week in the UAE. Weekly figures will be added if a public source starts publishing them.

Monthly

Home sales. Fewer homes are being sold each month. Total value is holding at about AED 21bn a month only because more expensive homes are selling. Compared with October last year, sales are down by about half.

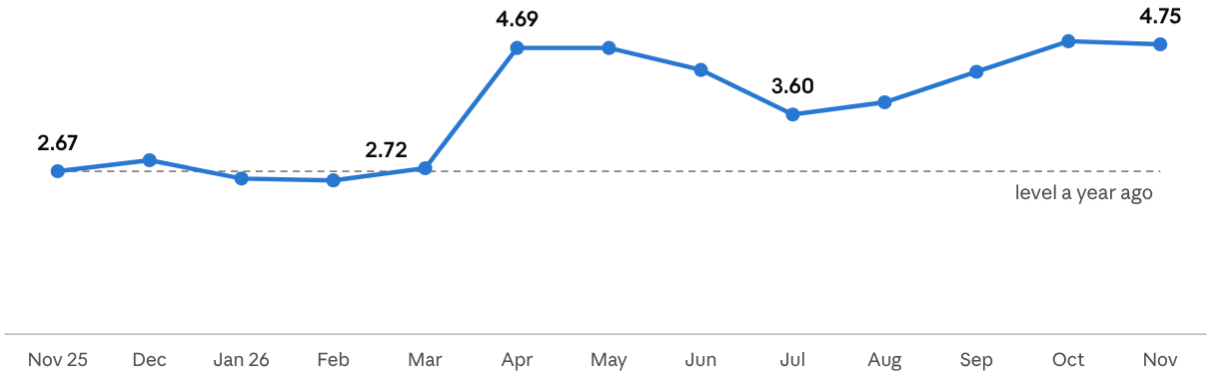
Homes sold in Dubai fell from about 12,600 in July to 10,000 in October

Homes sold per month, 2026. Value under each month.



Diesel jumped in April and is still far above last year

UAE diesel price, AED per litre. Now 78% higher than a year ago.



Home sales: Projectory monthly reports from Dubai Land Department data (homes only, no land, offices or mortgages). Diesel: UAE Fuel Price Committee via Gulf News, Khaleej Times and WAM

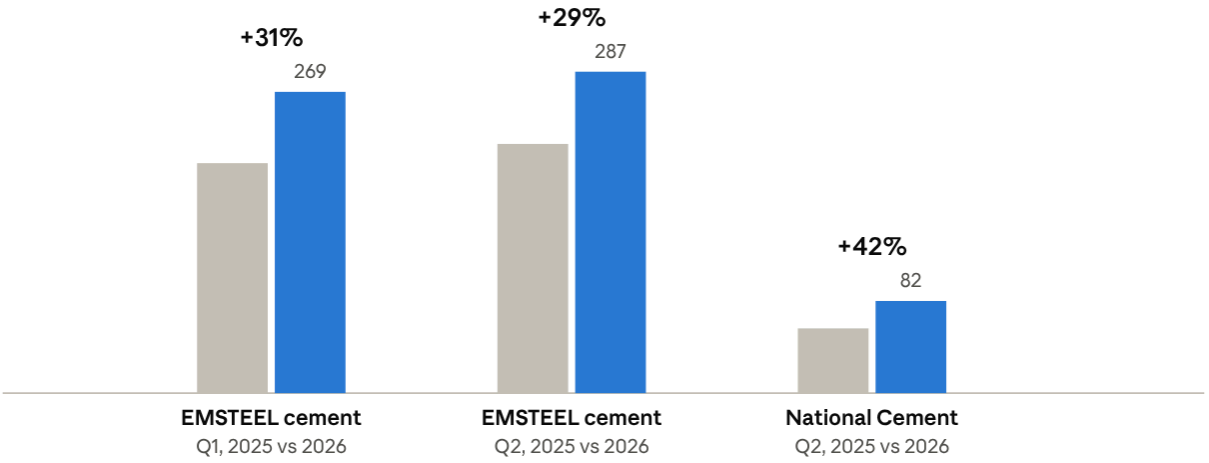
Building materials. Most materials makers do not publish monthly prices. Diesel is the best monthly guide to delivery cost. It jumped in April when the regional war pushed up oil prices, dropped in July, and has climbed back since.

Quarterly

Building materials. The cement companies with confirmed results sold more than in the same quarter last year.

Cement company sales were 29% to 42% higher than a year earlier

Quarterly sales, AED million. Grey = same quarter of 2025, blue = 2026.

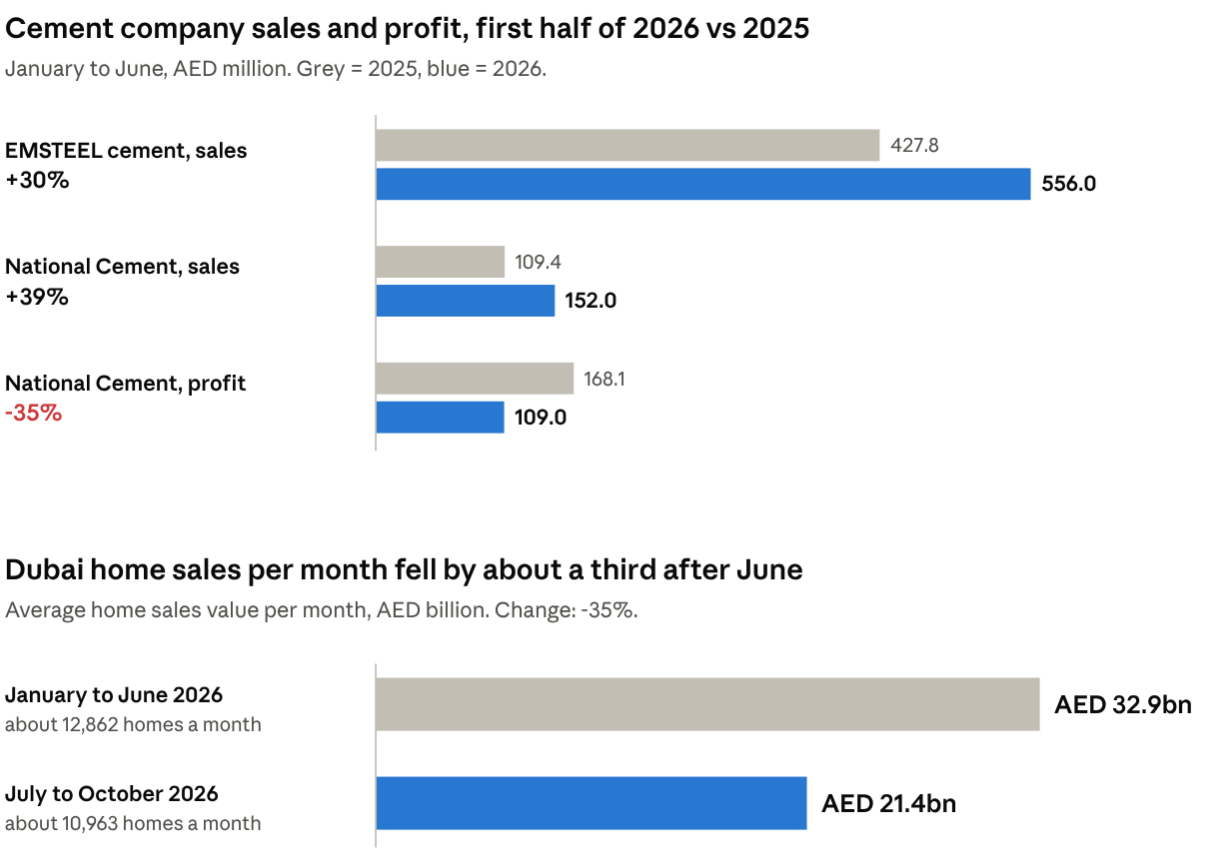


Company results: EMSTEEL and National Cement releases (via TradeArabia and CemNet). 2025 bars worked out from the growth each company reported

Home sales. From July to September, Dubai sold 33,854 homes worth AED 64.1bn (Projectory). No matching quarterly figure for last year is published on the same basis, so the yearly view below is the better comparison.

Half-yearly

Building materials and home sales are moving in opposite directions. Cement companies sold more in the first half of 2026 than a year earlier. Over the same period, home sales slowed after June.

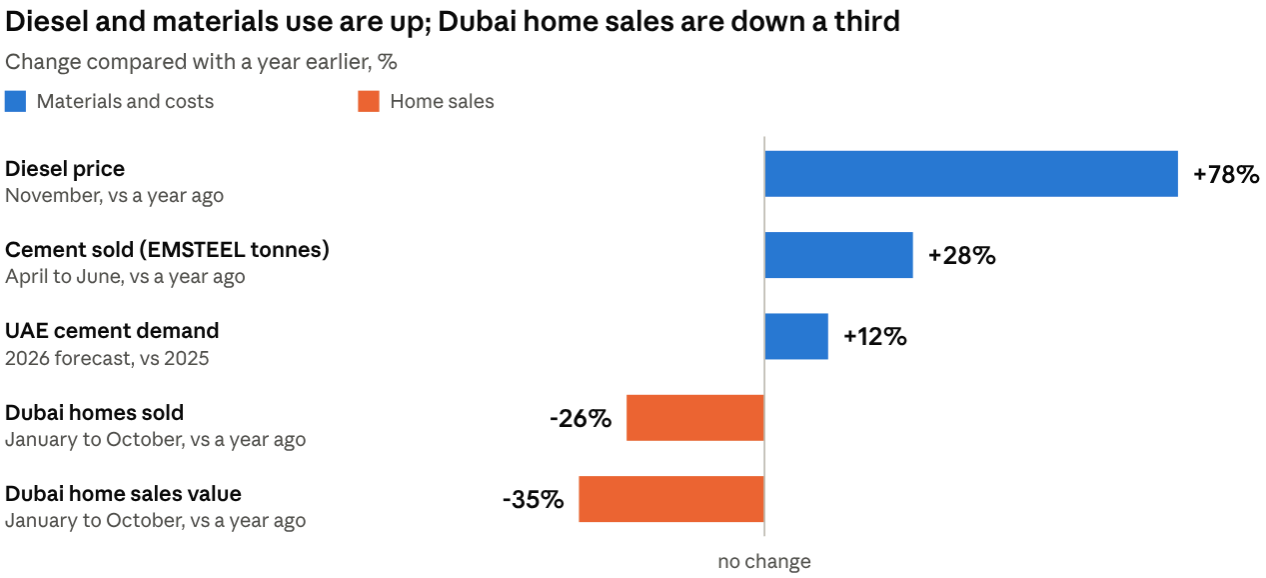


Company results: EMSTEEL and National Cement releases (via TradeArabia and CemNet); 2025 sales worked out from the growth each company reported. Home sales: Projectory (Jan-Sep and Jan-Oct totals, July-September monthly reports); first-half figure worked out from these

National Cement's profit fell even though its sales grew, because it received less money from its investments in other companies.

Yearly

More building materials are being used, while home sales are down.



Diesel: UAE Fuel Price Committee. EMSTEEL: Q2 2026 results. Cement demand: Ken Research (21.0 Mt in 2025, about 23.5 Mt in 2026). Dubai home sales: Projectory, from Dubai Land Department data

Construction materials are still selling well this year because homes sold in 2024 and 2025 are still being built. The drop in home sales has not reached materials demand yet. It will start to show in 2027 and 2028 unless home sales pick up again.

Company results and prices

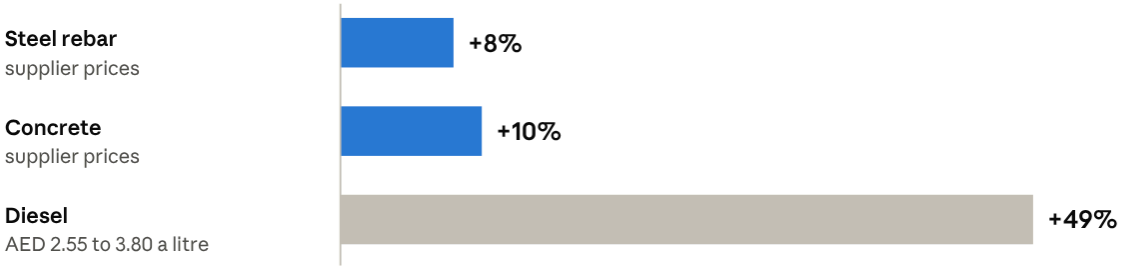
Cement companies are selling more than a year ago. The table shows only results confirmed from company releases. Other listed cement companies will be added once their figures are confirmed in stock exchange filings.

Company	Period	Revenue (AED m)	Net profit (AED m)	Profit vs a year ago	Note
EMSTEEL, cement division	Apr-Jun 2026	287 (+29%)	not given	—	Cement division only; EBITDA AED 75m; tonnes sold 1.1 Mt (+28%); July-September results due mid-November
National Cement	Apr-Jun 2026	82.3 (+42.3%)	33.7	Up from 10.9	First-half profit fell to 109.0 from 168.1 because dividends from its investments fell

The chart and table below show how the prices of building materials and diesel changed this year.

How steel, concrete and diesel prices changed, January to August 2026

Change in price, %, January to 31 August 2026

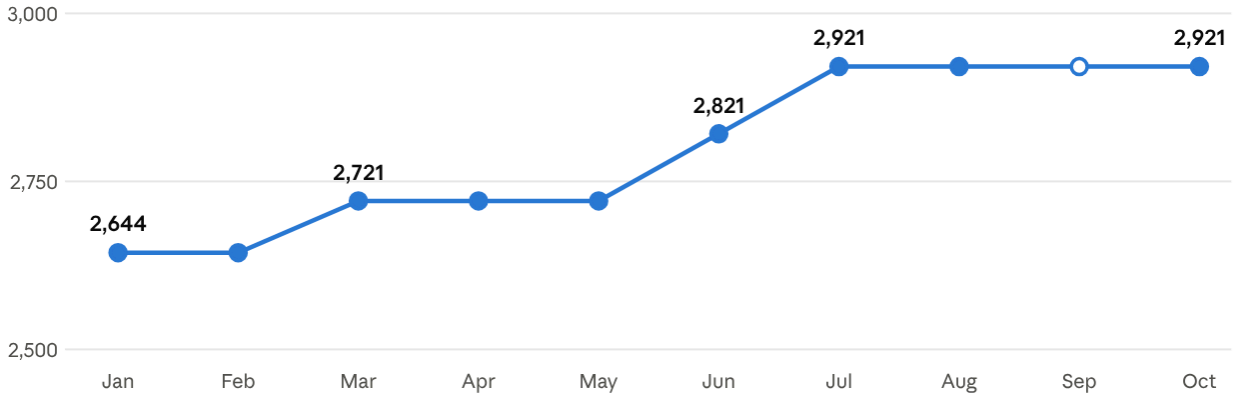


Cement, concrete and rebar: Currie & Brown, supplier prices to 31 August 2026 (via Arabian Business and EnterpriseAM). Diesel: UAE Fuel Price Committee, January and August 2026 prices; % worked out. No public source publishes UAE cement prices month by month, so only the change over the period is shown

Steel rebar, month by month. Emirates Steel publishes its rebar price every month, so the full trend can be shown.

Steel rebar price by month, 2026

Emirates Steel, 12-32 mm rebar, AED per tonne at the mill, before VAT. Jan to Oct: +10%.



Hollow point: no separate September report; October report says the price was unchanged for three months.

Emirates Steel monthly price announcements, via MEsteel and SteelOrbis (January to October 2026)

Item	Latest	Change	Source
Concrete / steel rebar	—	+10% / +8% since January	Same
Steel rebar, Emirates Steel (12-32 mm, at the mill)	AED 2,921/t, October	+10% since January (AED 2,644)	MEsteel / SteelOrbis
UAE business activity index (PMI; above 50 means growing)	54.8 in October	Down from 55.3; output prices rising at the fastest rate in the survey's history	Arab News, 4 Nov 2026

Item	Latest	Change	Source
Diesel	AED 4.75/litre, November	+78% vs AED 2.67 in Nov 2025	Khaleej Times · The Week
Coal price (fuel for cement kilns)	USD 150.35/t, 14 Oct	—	cnyes
Imported building materials	—	+20-25% vs before the regional war	Khaleej Times / Moody's

Al Bina does not report cement prices. For cement it reports demand: how much the UAE uses (see At a glance and the deep dive). Steel, concrete and fuel prices are shown only where a public source publishes them.

Contracts are changing because of rising costs. Long projects now often allow prices to change during the work, price quotes are valid for less time (some steel prices for only about 30 days), and contractors avoid fixed-price deals.

Project tracker: major UAE projects

This tracker lists the big projects that will use construction materials in the coming years, in every emirate. It covers projects worth about AED 1bn or more, plus a few big ones whose value is not yet public. It does not list every single building.

Most of the work still to be signed is infrastructure

28 major UAE projects by stage: 16 infrastructure, 12 real estate

Infrastructure Real estate

Planned or announced (9)

- **Emaar new mega community** — Dubai · AED 200bn
- **Abu Dhabi PPP projects (24)** — Abu Dhabi · AED 55bn
- **Aldar Saadiyat and Yas land** — Abu Dhabi · AED 23bn
- **New federal motorway (E-911)** — Dubai to RAK · AED 6bn
- **Aldar Yas Point** — Abu Dhabi · AED 6bn
- **Road beside Sheikh Zayed Road** — Dubai · value not given
- **Pink and Purple metro lines** — Dubai · value not given
- **Aldar five new communities** — Abu Dhabi · value not given
- **Marjan Beach** — Ras Al Khaimah · 22,000 homes planned

Contracts being signed (5)

- **Dubai sewage tunnels (DSST)** — Dubai · AED 80bn incl. running
- **Al Maktoum airport, other parts** — Dubai · over AED 55bn
- **Dubai Metro Gold Line** — Dubai · AED 34bn
- **Jebel Ali sewage plant** — Dubai · value not given
- **Hassyan seawater pipeline** — Dubai · value not given

Being built now (14)

- **Aljada (Arada)** — Sharjah · AED 35bn scheme
- **Etihad Rail high-speed line** — Abu Dhabi to Dubai · AED 24-29bn
- **Dubai Metro Blue Line** — Dubai · AED 20.5bn
- **Wynn Al Marjan Island** — Ras Al Khaimah · about AED 18.7bn
- **Al Maktoum West Terminal base** — Dubai · AED 10bn
- **Palm Jebel Ali (Nakheel)** — Dubai · AED 8.5bn contracts
- **Dubai South (Hayat, South Bay)** — Dubai · AED 3.5bn contracts
- **Abu Dhabi drainage (Tasreef 2)** — Abu Dhabi · AED 2.5bn
- **Latifa bint Hamdan Corridor** — Dubai · AED 2bn
- **Al Meydan Street upgrade** — Dubai · AED 1.2bn
- **Dubai Islands (Nakheel)** — Dubai · AED 0.8bn+ contracts
- **Dubai Loop tunnel (pilot)** — Dubai · 6.4 km, starts late 2026
- **Dubai Creek Harbour (Emaar)** — Dubai · value not given
- **Expo City homes** — Dubai · value not given

Al Bina project list from public announcements, MEED, Dubai Media Office, Etihad Rail, developer releases and press, as of 8 Nov 2026. Values are as announced and measure different things (contract, scheme or programme), so they should not be added together

What it shows: many housing and resort projects are already being built and will use construction materials for two to three more years. The large contracts still to be signed are mostly infrastructure: the airport, the Gold Line and the sewage tunnels. This is why infrastructure takes over as the main driver of construction materials demand from 2027.

Infrastructure projects

Project	Where	Value	Stage and dates	What it means for materials demand
Al Maktoum airport, other parts	Dubai South	Over AED 55bn to be signed	Due to be signed by end-2026	The biggest single source of new concrete from 2027
Al Maktoum West Terminal foundations	Dubai South	About AED 10bn	Signed 9 Oct 2026 (CCECC / Tristar)	Foundation work starts first, so it uses a lot of concrete early
Dubai sewage tunnels (DSST)	Dubai: Jebel Ali and Warsan	AED 80bn including years of running costs; about AED 30bn to build	Preferred bidders picked for two parts; third part bids due Sep 2026	Deep tunnels and 200 km of pipes; needs sulphate-resistant and GGBS blends
Dubai Metro Gold Line	Dubai: Al Ghubaiba to Jumeirah Golf Estates	About AED 34bn	Builders bidding now; contract in 2027; opens Sep 2032	42 km, all underground: large tunnel and station concrete from 2028
Dubai Metro Blue Line	Dubai: Creek to Academic City	AED 20.5bn	Being built; tunnelling since May 2026; opens 2029	Has its own two concrete plants, so materials go to them directly
Etihad Rail high-speed line	Abu Dhabi to Dubai	About AED 24-29bn	Contracts signed Feb 2026	150 km with tunnels and bridges; concrete through 2030
Latifa bint Hamdan Corridor	Dubai	AED 2bn	Signed Jul 2026	12 km of new road and bridges
Al Meydan Street upgrade	Dubai	AED 1.2bn	Signed Aug 2026	Bridges and junctions

Project	Where	Value	Stage and dates	What it means for materials demand
Road beside Sheikh Zayed Road	Dubai	Several billion (not given)	Contractors applied by Oct 2026	About 15 km of raised road on columns
New federal motorway (E-911)	Dubai, Sharjah, Ajman to RAK	AED 6bn	Design stage; consultant bids Oct 2026	68 km; demand in Sharjah and Ajman from 2027-28
Abu Dhabi PPP projects	Abu Dhabi	AED 55bn across 24 projects	To come to market in 2026-27	Schools, roads and utilities; steady demand in Abu Dhabi
Abu Dhabi drainage (Tasreef 2)	Abu Dhabi	AED 2.5bn	Five contracts signed	Pipes, tanks and pumping stations
Jebel Ali sewage plant expansion	Dubai	Not given	Bids in Jul 2026; award pending	Big concrete tanks; sulphate-resistant cement
Hassyan seawater pipeline	Dubai	Not given	Eight bids in Jul 2026; award pending	Pipe bedding and structures
Dubai Loop tunnel (pilot)	Dubai	Not given	Building from late 2026	6.4 km small tunnel; limited materials use
Pink and Purple metro lines	Dubai	Not given	Early planning	Possible demand after 2030

Real estate projects

Project	Where	Value or size	Stage and dates	What it means for materials demand
Emaar new mega community	Dubai (site not yet named)	AED 200bn; homes for 150,000 people	Announced Jun 2026; no launch yet	Biggest housing project in the pipeline; materials demand only after launch and sales, so 2028 or later
Aljada (Arada)	Sharjah	AED 35bn scheme; 25,000 homes	Being built; AED 2bn contracts for 2,210 homes in Mar 2026	Steady demand in Sharjah for several years
Wynn Al Marjan Island	Ras Al Khaimah	About AED 18.7bn	Tower topped out, rooms being fitted out; opening September 2027 (Wynn, Aug 2026)	Concrete work mostly done; demand moves to nearby projects
Marjan Beach	Ras Al Khaimah	22,000 homes and 12,000 hotel rooms planned (Marjan, Oct 2025)	Planned	Large future demand in RAK if it goes ahead
Palm Jebel Ali (Nakheel)	Dubai	AED 5bn of infrastructure and AED 3.5bn of villa contracts	Being built; first villa handovers from late 2026 to 2028	Marine works and villas near Jebel Ali through 2028 and beyond
Dubai Islands (Nakheel)	Dubai, off Deira	Bay Grove main contract over AED 800m; more launches	Being built	One of the few big Dubai housing areas still adding buildings
Dubai South: Hayat and South Bay	Dubai South	AED 2bn (Hayat) and AED 1.5bn (South Bay) contracts	Being built	Housing next to the new airport keeps growing

Project	Where	Value or size	Stage and dates	What it means for materials demand
Dubai Creek Harbour (Emaar)	Dubai	Not given	Being built; Creek Tower tender planned in 2026	Towers need high-strength concrete
Expo City homes	Dubai South	Not given	Being built or near handover	Mostly finished; little new demand
The Oasis and Grand Polo (Emaar)	Dubai	Not given	Being built	Villa communities; steady demand
Aldar Saadiyat and Yas land	Abu Dhabi	About AED 23bn; 3,000 homes	Planned	Abu Dhabi housing demand from 2027
Aldar Yas Point	Abu Dhabi	AED 6bn; 1,600 homes and a resort	Announced Jul 2026	Demand from 2027-28
Aldar five new communities	Abu Dhabi	Over 20 million m² of land; value not given	To launch in 2026-27	A large long-term pipeline in Abu Dhabi
Fibrex: Seamont residences	Abu Dhabi	About AED 0.8bn	Signed 9 Oct 2026	New housing still starting in Abu Dhabi

Reading the two tables together: Dubai housing is slowing, but Sharjah, Ras Al Khaimah and Abu Dhabi still have big housing projects under way or planned. Together with the airport, metro and sewage tunnels, this supports construction materials demand across the UAE even as new Dubai launches fall.

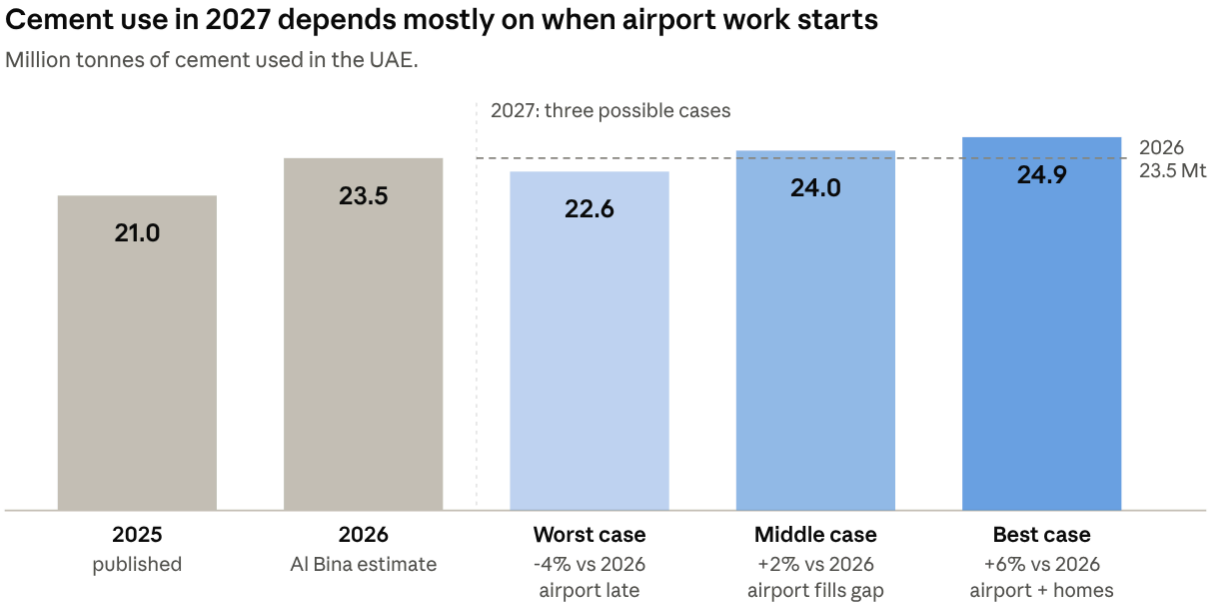
This list covers publicly announced projects as of 8 November 2026. Values come from government, developer and press announcements and are not all measured the same way.

Deep dive: can airport and metro work fill the housing gap?

Al Bina's own analysis of the figures in this issue

This year Dubai is finishing a record number of homes, which keeps construction materials sales high. But far fewer new homes are being started for 2027 and 2028. The big question is whether work on the new Al Maktoum airport and the rail lines starts in

time to fill that gap.



Al Bina calculation: Ken Research 2025 demand and 2026 growth forecast; 2027 cases as set out in Materials demand estimates

The difference between the worst and best case is 2.3 million tonnes, about five weeks of all the cement the UAE uses.

How the three cases are worked out

Al Bina estimates UAE demand in 2026 at about 23.5 Mt of cement, 47 million m³ of ready-mix concrete and 6.2 Mt of rebar.

Material	2025 (published)	2026	2027 worst	2027 middle	2027 best
Cement (Mt)	21.0	23.5	22.6	24.0	24.9
Ready-mix concrete (million m³)	42.2	47.2	45.4	48.2	50.0
Steel rebar (Mt)	5.5	6.2	5.9	6.3	6.5
GGBS (Mt)	not published	3.8-5.7	3.6-5.4	3.9-5.8	4.0-6.0
Aggregates for concrete (Mt)	not published	87	84	89	93

How the estimates are built (Al Bina calculation):

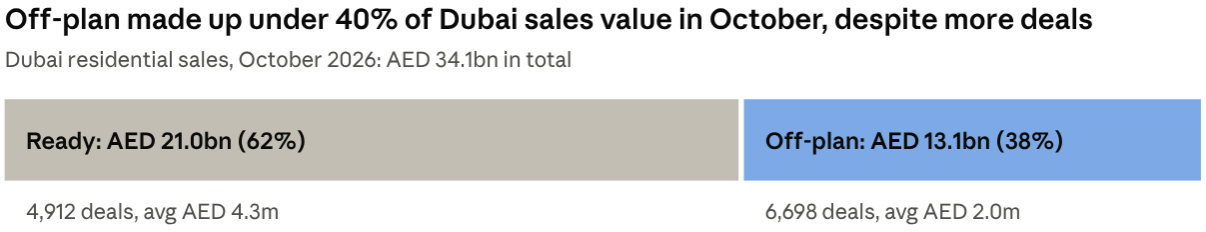
- **Cement 2026:** Ken Research forecasts about 23.5 Mt, up from 21.0 Mt in 2025. 2027 cases: worst -4% (fewer homes start, airport late), middle +2% (airport makes up for housing), best +6% (airport speeds up and off-plan sales recover). For comparison, Ken Research forecasts about 24.6 Mt for 2027 (+5.3%), between Al Bina's middle and best cases.

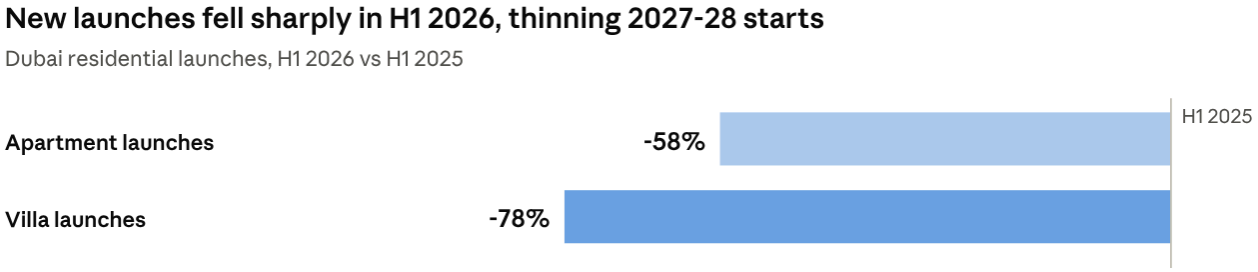
- **Ready-mix concrete:** 2.01 m³ per tonne of cement, the 2025 ratio of 42.2 million m³ (Ken Research) to 21.0 Mt of cement, held constant.
- **Rebar:** 0.26 t per tonne of cement, the 2025 ratio using 5.5 Mt of rebar use reported by EMSTEEL's CEO. Cross-check: traders put monthly use at 500,000-550,000 t (SteelOrbis), or 6.0-6.6 Mt a year.
- **GGBS:** 80-120 kg per m³ of ready-mix. This is an assumption; no public source tracks UAE GGBS volumes.
- **Aggregates:** 1.85 t per m³ of concrete, a standard mix-design figure. Road base and fill are not included.

These are planning estimates, not forecasts of any company's sales. Al Bina updates the ratios each quarter as new published data arrives.

Homes: many finishing now, few new ones starting

Dubai expects about 55,600 handovers in 2026, the most since 2008 (Cushman & Wakefield forecast; Cavendish Maxwell expects fewer), with 32,000 of them in the second half. Most of the concrete for those homes will be poured by mid-2027. What comes next depends on new projects and on homes sold before they are built (off-plan). Both are falling.





DLD via Emirates 24|7, 31 Oct 2026 (October sales); Cushman & Wakefield Core via Khaleej Times, 20 Aug 2026 (H1 launches)

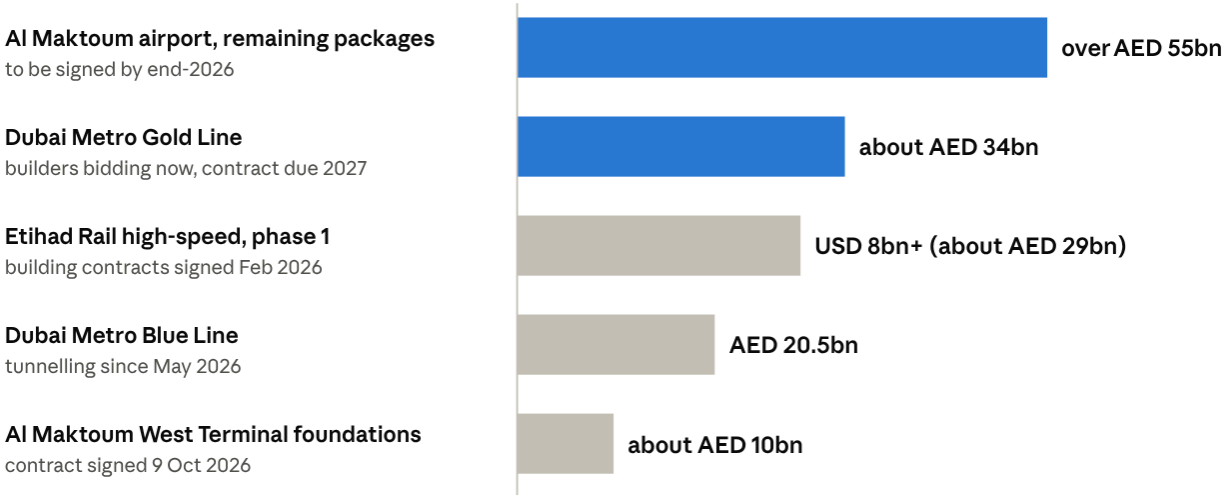
People are still buying off-plan, but cheaper homes: the average off-plan sale is less than half the price of a finished home. Developers have also started far fewer new projects. Of the 525,000 homes planned up to 2030, only about 186,000 are more than one-fifth built. The first good sign would be off-plan sales back above about 9,000 a month.

Airport, rail and metro: big projects, slow to start

Four big projects will use most of the new concrete outside housing. Work on the rail line and the metro has already started. The two biggest, most of the new Al Maktoum airport and the Gold Line metro, have not been given to builders yet. When they are, infrastructure becomes the main source of new construction materials demand.

Nearly AED 90bn of airport and metro work is still to be signed

Project value, AED billion. Blue = contracts not yet signed.

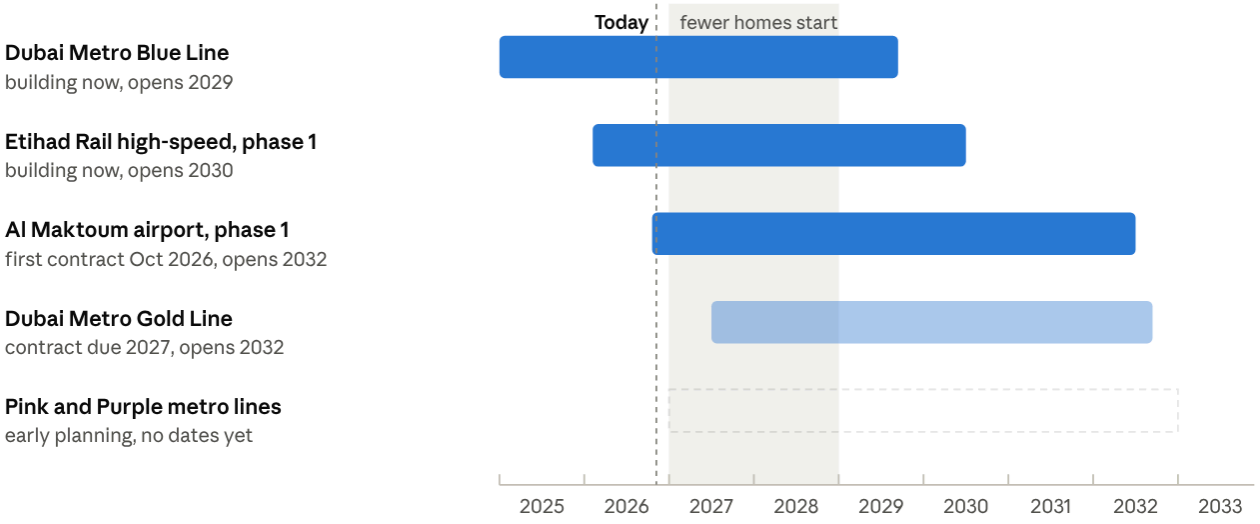


Dubai Media Office and RTA announcements; MEED; Etihad Rail; USD converted at AED 3.6725. Values are not additive: airport packages may overlap

In Al Bina's view, contracts signed in December will only need large amounts of concrete from around mid-2027, after design and groundwork are done. That is why the middle case only just makes up for fewer new homes, and why the worst case could happen. Gas projects were the biggest new contracts from July to September, but they use little concrete or steel.

Rail and airport work runs through the years when fewer homes start

When each project needs concrete. Dark blue = building now, light blue = contract coming.



Dubai Media Office (Gold Line, 22 Apr 2026); RTA and MEED (Blue Line, Pink and Purple lines); Etihad Rail; Dubai Aviation. Bar lengths are approximate building periods based on announced dates

These projects overlap the years when fewer new homes start (shaded). They will not replace all the materials that housing used straight away, but they keep demand going into the early 2030s. Tunnels, stations and airport foundations also use more GGBS blends and sulphate-resistant cement than housing does. The Pink and Purple metro lines would add more demand if they go ahead; they can be added here once costs and dates are published.

What to watch

Three things will show which way 2027 goes:

1. **When airport contracts are signed.** If they are signed by December, the middle case holds. If they slip to mid-2027, materials use moves towards the worst case.
2. **Off-plan home sales.** More than about 9,000 a month would point to the best case. Around 6,700 a month means fewer new homes will be built.
3. **Delivery cost.** Diesel costs about 78% more than last year.

Where the demand will be: in 2027, construction materials will be needed in different places and of different types. By place: less in housing areas such as JVC and Business Bay, more in Dubai South and Jebel Ali. By type: more GGBS blends and sulphate-resistant cement for tunnels, airport foundations and water plants.

Outlook and what to watch

Home completions and metro work keep building activity high in the last three months of 2026. 2027 depends on whether airport, metro and rail work starts in time to replace fewer new homes.

1. **October to December 2026: busy.** About 32,000 Dubai homes are due for handover in the second half of the year and the Blue Line metro aims to be 30% built by the end of the year.
2. **January to June 2027: from homes to infrastructure.** Concrete for homes falls as this year's big wave of completed homes ends. How big the dip is depends on how fast foundation work at Al Maktoum airport speeds up.
3. **Costs: a small drop, not a turnaround.** November fuel prices were cut after three monthly increases, but diesel remains about 78% above a year ago. Moody's does not expect shipping and trade to return to normal before 2027.

What Al Bina will report in the next issue:

- [ ] EMSTEEL's July to September cement sales (expected mid-November)
- [ ] Number of off-plan homes sold in Dubai in November (Dubai Land Department)
- [ ] Which builders win the remaining Al Maktoum airport contracts
- [ ] December fuel price (announced 30 November)
- [ ] Fujairah Cement's July to September results
- [ ] Gold Line metro: which builders are shortlisted, and when the contract will be signed

Calendar

- **Mid-November:** EMSTEEL July to September results
- **23-26 November:** Big 5 Global, Dubai World Trade Centre, the region's main construction and building-materials show, with the co-located Totally Concrete event
- **30 November:** December fuel prices announced
- **By 31 December:** remaining Al Maktoum airport packages due for award

Sources and method

Al Bina uses public sources only: Dubai Land Department and Abu Dhabi Real Estate Centre data as reported by the press, ADX and DFM company filings, government and RTA announcements, MEED and Kamco Invest project data, consultancy reports (Cushman & Wakefield Core, Savills, Currie & Brown, Moody's) and the UAE Fuel Price Committee. Figures are as published; Al Bina calculations are labelled. Nothing in this issue comes from any company's private data.

Additional sources this issue: Ken Research market sizes, SteelOrbis rebar trade reports, Argaam and CNBC Arabia company-results coverage, S&P Global PMI as reported by Arab News, and benchmark fuel prices. Demand estimates are Al Bina calculations built from these published figures, with every ratio and assumption stated in the estimates section.

All figures are as of 8 November 2026 and come from public sources only. Al Bina reports published figures and lets readers draw their own conclusions; it does not forecast or recommend prices. Personal views, not affiliated with or representing any company. Not investment advice.
